

GUIDELINES FOR INTERNSHIPS ABROAD

Third Edition



THE FORUM
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INTRODUCTION

Internships abroad offer valuable and unique opportunities and challenges for students and the institutions and organizations that organize them. While internships abroad may seem similar to internships in a home country, there are additional considerations when they take place in another country.

For students, adjusting to a new setting and culture is common to all education abroad experiences. Interns abroad must also learn to navigate the intricacies of the culture of work at their internship site. Additionally, an internship abroad may represent a student's first professional work experience, which is another challenging transition. Together, these factors require additional preparation, support, and reflection.

For institutions and organizations, there are many moving parts to manage. Students can go abroad with interning as the primary goal or as one part of their academic program. On home campuses, students may seek advising for international internship opportunities from either the education abroad office, the career services office, or their academic department. Generally, career services offices will have more expertise about the application process, challenges, and professional development associated with internships domestically, and education abroad offices are better equipped to navigate the logistics of experiences abroad and prepare students for the cross-cultural challenges that await them. For each, advising for internships abroad is qualitatively different from the advising they do for other types of programs. The best outcome results when these offices work together to ensure that colleagues across the institution, including faculty, are knowledgeable about internships abroad. Organizations coordinating internships can be instrumental in helping advisors understand how internships abroad have an added layer of complexity, and how to prepare and support students effectively.

In all cases, managing the expectations and relationships among the student, the internship site, the coordinating organization, and the multiple stakeholders at the home institution is key.

These guidelines can help stakeholders navigate those relationships by offering advice for addressing the specific needs and challenges presented by internships abroad. The [*Standards of Good Practice for Education Abroad*](#) apply to all education abroad opportunities. Use them together to develop and assess internships abroad.

TERMS AND DEFINITIONS

CAREER-INTEGRATED GLOBAL LEARNING

education abroad programs or program components that emphasize or incorporate professional exploration related to a student's future career path. In addition to internships and related terms, such as cooperative education (co-op) and work integrated learning (WIL), career-integrated global learning can also include industry-based projects, case studies, entrepreneurship initiatives, job shadowing, micro-internships, competency-based modules, and workplace simulations.

COORDINATING ORGANIZATION

institution or organization responsible for identifying internship sites and connecting students to internship opportunities.

HOME INSTITUTION

educational institution where an education abroad student is a continuing student, usually working toward the completion of a degree.

HOST INSTITUTION

educational institution where student is taking coursework during program, may be classified as visiting or short-term student on study abroad or exchange program.

INTERNSHIP

a form of experiential learning that integrates knowledge and theory learned in the classroom with practical application and competency development in a professional setting (NACE 2018). Attributes of an internship include:

- practical experience
- training opportunity
- extension of academic studies
- exposure to a professional setting
- dedicated workplace supervisor
- mentor or resources during program
- ongoing feedback from supervisor and mentor
- assessment and certification at conclusion

Note 1 to entry: Variations on the term internship and extensions of the methodology include cooperative education (co-op), work integrated learning (WIL), work-based learning, practicum, field work, traineeship, convention de stage, placements, apprenticeship, and training programs.

Note 2 to entry: Internships are considered [high-impact practices](#).

INTERNSHIP ABROAD

an experience in a professional setting that takes place outside of the country in which a student's home university is located. This professional, practical experience is viewed as an extension of coursework and an opportunity for training or professional exploration related to a student's future career path.

INTERNSHIP FACULTY

person or people who teach courses or assess student learning when the internship is attached to academic credit.

Note 1 to entry: Faculty members may include all types of professors and instructors, regardless of tenure or type of contract.

INTERNSHIP SITE

workplace where the student completes their internship. Also called internship placement or host organization.

INTERNSHIP SUPERVISOR

professional employed by the internship site who is responsible for overseeing the work and training of an intern in their workplace and for reporting back to the coordinating organization or institution regarding the student's progress. Also called workplace mentor or host organization supervisor.

ONLINE GLOBAL INTERNSHIP

internship abroad delivered via online modality and not including travel to the location. Also called remote internship or virtual internship.

PARTNER

party involved in the processes of sending students abroad or receiving students abroad (when at least two parties are involved), including, but not limited to:

- home institution
- host institution
- independent provider
- consortium
- travel or logistics provider
- government agency
- scholarship organization

Note 1 to entry: Education abroad is by its very nature collaborative. Partner relationships are not always formal partnerships but working relationships with entities that may include, but are not limited to, travel agents or local transportation providers.

PROGRAM SPONSOR

institution or organization that sponsors the internship program. Specific to internships abroad, program sponsors coordinate required paperwork for visa or work authorization processing.

GUIDING PRINCIPLES

4.1* MISSION AND GOALS

*For ease of reference, sections are numbered to match the corresponding clauses of the [*Standards of Good Practice for Education Abroad, 6th Edition*](#).

- a. Establish that the primary goal for an internship abroad is to provide students learning opportunities in professional settings intentionally designed to strengthen their ability to integrate knowledge and theory through practical application, to foster developmental relationships, which together contribute to their academic, professional and intercultural learning and development.
- b. Consider how the internship program can be designed to enact the elements of [*high-impact practices*](#) to deepen learning and support student retention and success. These elements include:
 1. Performance expectations set at appropriately high levels
 2. Significant investment of time and effort by students over an extended period of time
 3. Interactions with faculty and peers about substantive matters
 4. Experiences with diversity wherein students are exposed to and must contend with people and circumstances that differ from those with which students are familiar
 5. Frequent, timely, and constructive feedback
 6. Periodic, structured opportunities to reflect and integrate learning
 7. Opportunities to discover relevance of learning through real-world applications
 8. Public demonstration of competence

- c. Clearly articulate how the internship program relates to, supports, and enhances the institution or education abroad organization's mission and goals as part of a comprehensive global learning portfolio.

4.2 COLLABORATION AND TRANSPARENCY

- a. Balance the interests of multiple stakeholders (students, internship faculty, internship supervisors, internship sites, coordinating organizations, and home and host institutions) while promoting transparency of process, clear learning goals, professional workplace standards, and the ideals of reciprocity and mutual benefit.
- b. Establish that the purpose of the internship experience is to foster student learning about a specific field or career, and help understand how a particular field approaches its work in a range of cross-cultural and global contexts. The learning, experiences, and network the student takes away from their experience may contribute to their future employability.
- c. Select coordinating organizations and internship sites with the following criteria in mind:
 1. Commitment to placing interns in relevant and developmentally appropriate experiences
 2. Capacity to manage, mentor, and supervise interns to support both student learning and development and foster meaningful student contributions to the mission and goals of the internship site
 3. Ability to provide professional development relevant to the local culture and professional context
 4. Comprehensive health, safety, security, and risk management policies
 5. Adherence to international, national, and local laws

- d. Articulate clear expectations for all stakeholders throughout all phases of the program, including potential consequences if any party fails to meet expectations.
- e. Share internship program learning objectives and workplace assessment metrics with internship supervisors.
- f. Confirm that projects and tasks are substantive but appropriate for a student, and that students are not asked to perform tasks beyond their level of training and skill.
- g. Ensure that the internship site identifies experienced professional(s) who can effectively mentor, supervise, and assess interns.
- h. Offer students professional development support necessary to secure an internship placement, e.g., articulating goals, preparing relevant resumes and cover letters, and honing interview skills.
- i. Involve internship sites in the interview and intern matching process as much as possible, to enhance information sharing and ease student integration into the workplace.
- j. Provide clear channels of communication between and regular opportunities for feedback from students, internship sites, coordinating organizations, and home institutions.
- k. Partner with local colleagues and industry experts to identify respectful and appropriate behaviors in the workplace and the community.
- l. Ensure that the internship site's workplace or online work environment is professional and includes protections against discrimination, harassment, and exploitation.
- m. Aim to create relationships of reciprocity and mutual benefit between students, internship sites, coordinating organizations, and home institutions.

- n. Regularly evaluate to ensure that program goals and responsibilities are being met.
- o. Incorporate local knowledge in all stages of development, implementation, and evaluation.

4.3 ETHICS

- a. Ensure honest and transparent communication regarding the preparation and abilities of students between home institutions, coordinating organizations, and internship sites.
- b. Make efforts to establish trusting, sustainable relationships that ensure the internship is mutually beneficial to the student and the internship site.
- c. Maintain student privacy to the extent possible. For example, medical information is disclosed to internship placements only when necessary, and only with permission from the student.
- d. Where available, provide students with guidance related to the accepted code(s) of professional ethics for the field in which they are working.
- e. Engage with and recognize existing industries and organizations. Interns should not displace, disregard, or circumvent local workers.
- f. Inform students that coordinating organization and/or home institution codes of conduct and professional ethical standards also apply when students are in the internship setting.
- g. Ensure that students and supervisors are aware of consequences for inappropriate behavior and/or non-compliance.
- h. Ensure that students understand that commitment to their work means that missing work may only occur under specific circumstances as allowed by the internship site. For example, personal independent travel is planned around the work schedule.

- i. Encourage internship supervisors to communicate clearly and with as much notice as possible any specific work activities that the student will be expected to attend outside of their normal working hours.
- j. Make students aware of their obligation to act within the limits of their knowledge and competencies and within the role prescribed for them as interns.
- k. Inform students of their responsibility to know the limitations of their work hours, pay (if applicable), and other restrictions that may be governed by their host country visa.
- l. Assist and guide students to communicate with their supervisor on matters and requests that involve non-compliance with visa restrictions.
- m. Identify any confidentiality, non-disclosure and/or non-compete, licensing, research ethics, data privacy and security, etc. with which students or the internship sites are required to comply.
- n. Consider and prepare for the impact of the placement and student presence on local and organizational resources, economic conditions, and social, cultural, or political circumstances.
- o. Match student capacity, including knowledge, skills, and competencies, with the capacity necessary for the experience so that local resources are not compromised.

- p. When the internship involves work with vulnerable and/or low-resource communities, ensure that students receive training appropriate for work with these populations.
- q. Instruct students on appropriate use of technology/social media and sharing information about the internship site and local community.
- r. Uphold the highest standards of ethics, integrity, and professionalism among staff, faculty, students, and partners.

4.4 EQUITY, DIVERSITY, AND INCLUSION

- a. Ensure that mechanisms for selecting, preparing, and advising students as well as facilitating and assessing learning are transparent, equitable, and consistent.
- b. Select coordinating organizations and internship sites with policies and protocols that reflect a commitment to equity, diversity, and inclusion.
- c. Aim to develop a range of internship opportunities that accurately reflect and enhance the local community.
- d. Build ongoing relationships with internship sites, whenever possible, to provide opportunity for collaboration and cumulative impact rather than a collection of individual one-off experiences.
- e. Discuss with students any expectations and cultural differences that may impact their internship experience, including local language, dress codes, gender roles, racial/ethnic differences, and conflict resolution in the workplace.

- f. Incorporate online global internships intentionally.
 - 1. The online modality can allow greater access to internships abroad given lower cost, increased flexibility, and fewer paperwork requirements.
 - 2. Additional structure may be needed to support preparation for and troubleshooting within the online work environment, including considerations regarding culture and time management and professional communications or connections.
 - 3. Ensure that online global internships and in person experiences are available to and valued by a full range of students. Provide financial support or alternate program structures where possible to increase accessibility.
 - 4. Consider incorporating internship sites that might not have been possible as on-site opportunities to expand reach and reinforce relevance of remote or hybrid work.
- g. Regularly review program and placement offerings with local stakeholders to understand and minimize any potential negative impact on the local economy, labor market, public health, environment, and community.

ADMINISTRATIVE FRAMEWORK

5.1 POLICIES, PROCEDURES, AND GUIDELINES

- a. Clearly delineate and agree upon roles and responsibilities of all parties, with care taken to assign responsibilities to the party best equipped with the knowledge and expertise to carry out each task.
- b. Make deadlines and timelines for the following clearly accessible to students who may be interested in an internship program:
 - 1. application to the program, and/or
 - 2. application directly to internship placement(s)
 - 3. interviews
 - 4. notification of acceptance
 - 5. confirmation of placement
 - 6. internship start and end dates
- c. Provide students with a detailed list of the internship program costs and any additional expenses for which they will be responsible.
- d. Review relevant individual student physical and mental health information prior to arrival on-site to identify any special considerations or accommodations that might need to be taken into account in the placement process.
- e. Maintain consistency among academic components of an internship for students across a sponsoring institution or coordinating organization regardless of their internship placement.

- f. Clearly communicate criteria for the awarding of academic credit for credit-bearing internships, which may include:
 1. Number of work hours required
 2. Method of verifying hours worked
 3. Attendance in an in-person or online class or seminar
 4. Readings, assignments, reflective journals, or other academic components
 5. Criteria, including deadlines, for evaluating assignments
- g. Require students to communicate with their home institution and academic department to verify requirements for completing an internship for credit when applicable.
- h. Inform students that a non-credit internship may impact their full-time student status, possibly affecting their financial aid and scholarship eligibility.
- i. Confirm visa and work authorization requirements for interns, which are often of a different type and/or have different requirements from traditional student visas.
- j. Provide students clear information regarding any potential health and safety risks and emergency planning specific to the internship setting.
- k. Educate students about their personal responsibility for their physical and mental wellbeing while abroad, including awareness of symptoms of workplace stress.
- l. Assist students in understanding and complying with local practices, laws, and public health requirements regarding vaccination, quarantine, self-isolation, social/physical distancing, use of personal protective equipment, etc., upon arrival to the program location, upon return to home country, and in any country through which participants must travel to reach their destinations.
- m. Ensure that work environments are safe for students and communicate to students up-to-date workplace policies regarding vaccination, quarantine, self-isolation, social/physical distancing, use of personal protective equipment, etc.
- n. Review potential liability for the internship site in case of negligence related to workplace safety.
- o. Develop contingency planning in the event of a health emergency, a closure of the workplace due to health or other natural disasters or emergencies and keep abreast of changing government regulations that may impact the health, safety, security, and/or well-being of student interns.
- p. Develop agreements around informed consent and waivers specific to the workplace setting that:
 1. Require participants to acknowledge that they understand risks associated with health threats;
 2. Require participants to consent to following workplace guidelines regarding testing, temperature and symptom checking, masks, social/physical distancing, quarantine/self-isolation, reporting of contact with infected individuals, etc.;
 3. Require participants to agree that they will not hold the coordinating organization or internship site legally or financially responsible if they become ill as a result of their own choices and behaviors;
 4. Convey the importance of disclosing relevant medical information, disability status, accommodation, or other specific needs.

5. Recognize that any liability waivers may have little or no validity in the host country; and
6. Communicate clear expectations for conduct and consequences of behaviors regarding:
 - i. Disciplinary sanctions for non-compliance and
 - ii. Appeals processes.
- q. Ensure that appropriate health, safety, and security measures are in place in case of emergency, including an emergency contact on location.
- r. Confirm the internship site is aware of policies and protocols in the event of an emergency involving a student.
- s. Provide site-specific guidance regarding sexual misconduct, local resources for protection and support, and instructions for accessing support from the coordinating organization and home institution.
- t. Establish a Code of Conduct for appropriate behavior in the workplace and online. Include consideration for: offensive language and content (which may be seen through a different cultural lens), culturally inappropriate behavior, cyber bullying, and more. Ensure that the code addresses pathways to safely report and consequences for inappropriate behaviors.
- u. Provide clear documentation, and follow relevant policies and procedures for tracking, responding to, and reporting critical incidents.
- v. Ensure all participants are properly insured for the duration of the program. This includes but is not limited to comprehensive international travel for participants and professional liability or host country equivalent.
- w. Establish clear policies regarding privacy issues that conform with applicable laws (GDPR, FERPA, cell phone data to do contract tracing, etc.)
- x. Ensure visual images and social media used in promotional materials and program information appropriately represent the student experience and the work they will do on-site.
- y. Identify stakeholders and resources to involve in decision-making during policy and procedure development, including global or national organizations as well as local or regional perspectives and additional colleagues and offices across campus.

5.2 FINANCIAL AND HUMAN RESOURCES

- a. Ensure that programs have adequate financial, human, and facility resources to provide a learning environment and access to professional development for students.
- b. Assist internship supervisors and other employees of the internship site to be prepared for the unique challenges and benefits of an international student intern through training or written resources. This is especially important in countries or industries where internships are less common.
- c. Provide the internship site with responsibilities associated with hosting paid and unpaid internships.
- d. Collaborate with internship supervisors to review specific criteria for internship oversight, performance monitoring, and evaluation before students begin their internships.
- e. Ensure the work environment and facilities (in-person or remote) are adequate and appropriate to the scope and nature of the work at hand.
- f. Confirm that students are equipped with the necessary tools to be successful as a remote or in- person intern.

- g. Consistently and regularly evaluate internship sites to ensure that they are complying with the agreed upon parameters of the internship and offering students a valuable learning experience.
- h. Regularly train and evaluate faculty and/or staff members who oversee internships on guidelines, principles, and best practices.
- i. Inform students of their options in case the internship site is unable to fulfill their obligation. To the extent possible, make efforts to arrange another internship or otherwise enable the student to earn academic credit (if applicable).
- j. Complete agreement documentation as mandated by the home institution, internship site, coordinating organization, etc.
- k. Provide students with comprehensive budgeting information, including additional expenses such as commuting, professional wardrobe, and work authorization paperwork administration.

STUDENT LEARNING AND DEVELOPMENT

6.1 BEFORE PROGRAM

- a. Articulate the internship program's learning objectives and their alignment to professional development and career readiness competencies.
- b. Identify appropriate student learning and development outcomes specific to the experience and communicate these to students.
- c. Encourage students to identify and outline their own academic, professional, intercultural, and personal goals for the experience in addition to those set by the program.
- d. Clearly articulate and confirm student understanding of the academic and professional responsibilities of the program.
- e. Distinguish between academic/for-credit and co-curricular/non-credit internships if both are offered.
- f. Ensure the best possible match between the internship placement and the student's goals, knowledge, skills, and competencies (including language competencies, if applicable).
- g. Provide students with the following information when confirming their internship placements:
 - 1. Name and description of the internship site
 - 2. A description of the scope and nature of internship responsibilities
 - 3. Respective roles of the student, the coordinating organization, the internship site, and the home institution
 - 4. Contact details for internship supervisor
 - 5. Time commitment (schedule, hours per day, number of weeks)

6. Knowledge and skills that will impact the student's success in the placement (including academic background, language ability)
 7. Expectations of professionalism and appropriate conduct unique to the host culture
 8. Anticipated company policy documentation, such as background checks, drug testing, confidentiality, privacy, or non-compete policies
 9. Information on commute
 10. Compensation and any benefits, if relevant
- h. Review logistical considerations and consider cultural context that may impact the internship experience, including dress code, punctuality, hierarchy, humor, language, gender roles, approach to conflict resolution, appropriate use of technology, and industry-specific norms.
 - i. Include in pre-departure and on-site orientation information about safety protocols when working at the internship site and training on what to do in specific case scenarios.
 - j. Provide resources to prepare students for safety and legal considerations specific to the internship site and the industry.

6.2 DURING PROGRAM

- a. Provide orientation that prepares interns to be responsible partners in their placements and to model professional conduct.
- b. Make students aware that what is acceptable within the culture of the workplace and in the local community may not be the same. Prepare them to be respectful and appropriate in both contexts.
- c. Within the first week of the student's internship placement, ensure the student and the internship supervisor meet to establish an agreed upon work plan based on the confirmed job description.
- d. Confirm that orientation activities at the internship site mirror the on-boarding of a traditional employee and include training on technology, safety protocols and internal systems as well as the content and context for the placement itself.
- e. Prompt students to be aware of and comply with policies internal to the internship site and applicable to the work at hand, e.g., licensing, research ethics, data privacy, and security.
- f. Review technology requirements and skills development opportunities as part of providing students and supervisors with supplemental resources.
- g. Educate and empower students to decline when asked to perform activities beyond the anticipated scope of the work plan or outside the acceptable range of internship site activities.
- h. Ensure that each student is adequately supervised by a professional and offered feedback on their work by a designated supervisor at the internship site.
- i. Confirm with students and supervisors all criteria for any performance reviews, assignments and evaluation.

- j. Establish a cadence for regular formal input and maintain open channels of communication for informal feedback from both students and supervisors.
- k. Establish protocols for students and supervisors to raise any issues or report incidents as part of navigating the internship.
- l. Ensure that mechanisms are in place to assess whether students are meeting learning objectives during the internship.
- m. Encourage students to incorporate learning goals that cultivate professional development and cultural competencies.
- n. Check in with students regularly and offer feedback and evaluation on both the academic and professional components of the internship during the program.
- o. Reinforce the student's responsibility to balance academic and internship obligations. Help students navigate conflicts that might arise to balance responsibilities.
- p. Introduce students to other aspects of the professional environment, e.g., informational interviews and social or community events.
- q. Give students tools, training, and resources to leverage their international internship experience in pursuit of further academic and professional opportunities.
- r. Guide and encourage students to reflect on how the internship is contributing to their academic, professional, and personal goals.
- s. Ensure that students are continually aware of the local context and provided with space to reflect, receive feedback and generate learning related to their internship experience.

6.3 AFTER PROGRAM

- a. Prepare students to articulate how their internship abroad has impacted academic, professional, intercultural, and personal growth.
- b. Collect program evaluations and performance assessments from students and supervisors.
- c. Incorporate student and supervisor feedback with academic summary to create an end of program report, capturing recommendations for future iterations.
- d. Prompt students to update their resume and LinkedIn profile with the internship abroad, perhaps through a workshop or resources developed in collaboration with the career office on campus.
- e. Provide examples of post-program communications with internship site colleagues and professional networks.
- f. Encourage students to connect internships abroad with local and regional industries or trends.
- g. Invite students to engage with program alumni networks.
- h. Consider implementing or expanding longitudinal surveys to determine employability and learning outcomes related to internships abroad.